



TOURISM-GO A'S STRONG SUIT

Goa is now a 365 days a year tourism destination. Tourism has always been Goa's strong suit, but the difference lies in the profile of visitors attracted by the multifaceted charms of this international tourist destination. Gone are the days when the beaches were assailed by low-budget tourists who exploited the land and gave nothing back. If you visit the scenic beaches today, you will see tourists paragliding before sunset and later unwinding with the choicest of spirits while sampling Goan, Indian, Portuguese, Italian, French or fusion cuisine that makes the best use of Goa's special spices. Such restaurants are viable throughout the year thanks to the economic prosperity unleashed by the IT and pharma industries which in turn generates more jobs.

Medical tourism is also a big draw with new hospitals on the verge of being commissioned in Mapusa, and also super speciality hospitals offering a one-stop destination in various fields of medicine such as cardiac care, cosmetic surgery, joint replacements, ophthalmology, and dentistry. These services are offered through some of the best medical experts and nursing care combined with state-of-the-art medical techniques and electronic equipment. As far as the health sector is concerned, Goa is the number one state in the country today with a Mediclaim scheme that provides up to Rs.1.5 lakh for bypass or angioplasty, Rs.3 lakh for kidney treatment, and Rs.5 lakh for cancer treatment. Recently, the government has started reimbursing a maximum of Rs.15,000 per month to kidney patients requiring dialysis. This is a unique scheme that does not exist anywhere else in the country.

Goa is now a happy blend of tourism and environmental friendly industry, an invigorating corner of India where business and leisure go hand in hand.

A big boost has been provided to agriculture not only to avert its further decline but also to make it economically viable. It has been noticed that while the 'return to the plough policy' with the introduction of scientific methods of cultivation has been a success, since Liberation the acreage under crops like paddy had been decreasing on account of rapid urbanization and costly labour. Special schemes have been designed to improve horticulture, cash crops like sugarcane, coconuts and mangoes, and floriculture. Subsidy on paddy cultivation has been raised considering the existence of uneconomic holdings. Similar facilities are being provided to animal husbandry, dairy farming, fisheries and pig breeding. Floriculture is now a priority activity, as is the establishment of Apiaries for bee-keeping. The setting up of the prestigious "Botanical Garden Cum Eco-Recreational Park" situated on the downstream side of the Salaulim Dam is another notable achievement.

The Tillari irrigation project, which is a joint venture of Goa and Maharashtra, has since been revived to bring an additional 14,521 hectares of land under irrigation.

MODEL WELFARE STATE

While Goa has been rated as one of the most healthy states in the country, the government is keen to expand medical facilities to weaker sections, particularly women in rural areas, children and senior citizens.

The government has started revitalising most of the socio-economic policies in order to abolish poverty and extending care to senior citizens, destitute persons and widows in distress, besides the urban poor. In fact, Goa's excellent performance in providing social security to various segments of the population has been recognized by the Centre. The Government is also working on a scheme to provide free education to girl students up to graduation level. Several girl students belonging to Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribes have benefited under the unique "Kanya Dhan" scheme.

Scheduled Tribes like Gawdas, Kunbis and Velips have been granted reservations in jobs and educational institutions. A new scheme called "Ummid" has been launched to provide day care to senior citizens wherein their requirements of recreation and light refreshments are taken care of by the government. Over 4,000 senior citizens living in destitute conditions are being provided a monthly dole of Rs. 1,000.

The Infogam scheme has been implemented in all the 189 village panchayats under which they have been provided with computers and other peripherals. Data work in all the panchayats has also been completed. Local self-governments are being provided administrative and financial powers listed under the 11th Schedule of the Indian Constitution. The Planning Process has now begun at the grass-roots level.



E-GOVERNANCE

Says the Chief Secretary J. P. Singh: "We have adopted a two pronged approach for ensuring good governance. The prime thrust is to bring about e-governance wherein the majority of citizens' interface with various agencies of the Government is off loaded to Citizen Service Centres (CSC) so as to reduce corruption and minimize the time period for issue of various permissions, licences, etc. Thus 2 PPP projects are presently in place so that Optical Fibre Cables will reach each home in Goa soon and citizens have access to internet bandwidth of 2 mbps to 10 mbps.

"The second thrust is to concentrate on system and procedural reforms as well as infrastructure upgradation in five key departments where there is maximum interaction with the common man i.e. Offices of the Collectorate, Police, Panchayats, Municipalities and Health Institutions."

Goa has come a long way since its liberation in 1961 and is well set to realize its dream of becoming a Model Welfare State - a dream that other states will want to emulate.